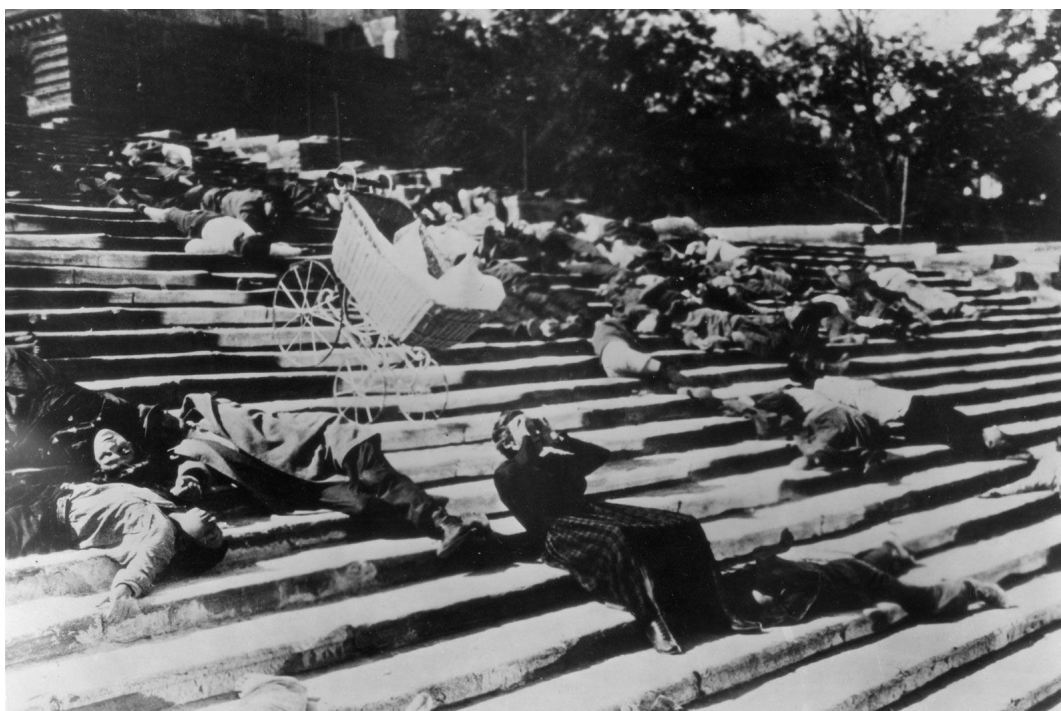


# Films of 1925



Rules: Given that we are going way back, there are hardly any rules. I might use US release date, I might use the international release date. It is worth point out that wide releases were not much of a thing, so even release dates can be tricky. I did seek out famous directors (Keaton, Lubitsch, Vidor; for example) as well famous stars (Rin-Tin-Tin, Lon Chaney, Lillian Gish; for example). If anything, the existence of an easily accessible copy of the film was the deciding factor. This is the second year I've purchased blu-rays from Grapevine Video, Flicker Alley, Undercrank Productions, and Film Preservation Society if one had it on blu-ray and it came out in 1925 I ordered the disc to expand my selection of films (they have a lot more available, but only on DVD).

That being said, short films were not considered. I will be defining a feature as a film longer than 40ish minutes.

## Tier 8: Avoid at All Costs

61. **Motherhood: Life's Greatest Miracle:** A preachy, and conservative film about – you guessed it – motherhood. One mother is talked out of an abortion (at least it was mentioned as an option? but quickly shutdown for moral reasons). The film follows two expectant mothers, and how 'lucky' they are to be pregnant and to become a mother. There is not much in the way of character development or drama. Rather these women get to become parents and that is all they are good for—literally. The film preaches conservative values around women's roles in society: women exist to have children. And women should be happy about this role. It is grating and awful. [In a Boxset on Women Directors]
60. **Wizard of Oz:** Written, directed, produced, and starring Larry Semon. And those are the four major problems of the film. Semon makes himself the star (even while his real-life wife plays Dorothy!), resulting in a weak plot with sidebars to focus on him attempting comedy, while then forgetting the motivations of all the other characters. [Britta Voice:] I can excuse the racism in the film (the film literally introduces a black character stealing and eating watermelon), but I draw the line at unfunny

bits. Semon has little comedic timing in the film, and often hams up his reactions. There are few funny bits, but often they take too long to develop. Any deviations from the source material can sorta be ignored (though the setting of an elderly man – also played by Semon – reading the book to a child is not needed), as those are not the main issues. [An OG Wizard of Oz]

### Tier 7: Standard Films Not Worth Watching (Sans a Single Redeeming Quality)

59. **Manasse:** A Romanian silent film about Jewish life. Therefore it is an interesting piece of history. Sadly, that is about where the niceties end. The film should have a lot a lot to say about Jewish identity a culture as the driving plot of a film is the marrying off of a Jewish daughter to another Jew instead of a Christian man she is in love with. That is a great piece of drama. Instead the film never sets up the drama or focuses on developing the characters much. There are far too many title cards (a cheap way of bringing down costs; the worst are when the title cards read, “No...”; this could easily be conveyed by the actors!) and almost no close ups. The poor directions squanders a good plot outline, as the film becomes a 85-minute slog. [On YouTube]
58. **The Pony Express:** I should be more grateful that a film of the era took a decidedly pro-union stance. Even ignoring that the film gets history completely wrong, the film lacks real characters and action (but apparently chunks of the film are lost). Wallace Beery and Betty Compson are in the film, but given little to do. Director James Cruze essentially remade his own *Covered Wagon*, but with less realism and less excitement. [On YouTube]
57. **The Mad Whirl:** A generic anti-alcohol film. A rich family of boozers and partiers finds that their son is falling in love with the poor church-going girl he went to school with—her father quit selling alcohol because of prohibition and instead sells soda and ice cream. You can imagine the forced morals along class, religion, and drinking. Don’t worry the son ‘reforms’ himself to get the girl. Nothing is really missed with this one. It never quite drags at a big over an hour, but there is little to make this film stand out in anyway. [On YouTube]
56. **The Plastic Age:** One of many goes-to-college films on the list. Most certainly the worst on the list. The seventy-minute film manages to cover the man character’s entire four years at college. The structure and pacing, does not work. The film also plays fast-and-loose with the other characters. His roommate already has kissed multiple girls on movie-in day? Clara Bow’s character hosts a frat hazing, yet ends up also being a freshman (and the girl who’s been kissed twice). The entire plot isn’t thought out, while also being entirely predictable. Clara Bow (*Down to the Sea in Ships*) in a pre-breakout is really the only bright spot in the film. [Clara Bow]
55. **The Unchastened Woman:** A film let down by poor direction. The film is notable for being the last feature film of Theda Bara who was the original film Vamp. Sadly almost all of her films are lost, and if this is what survives it does not do her any justice. The film itself is only fifty-five minutes, and in the first twenty minutes her character leaves her husband (while pregnant), goes to Europe, has the baby, becomes popular, and then returns to America, with her child, to get revenge on her cheating husband. There is no character development in that twenty minutes. Only a whirlwind of sets, costumes, boats, and parties. And then when her character returns to America, the audience starts counting down to when she’ll reunite with her husband. The answer: thirty-three minutes later. Outside of being one of the few surviving films of an 1910s star, there is not much of value. [Theda Bara]
54. **Womanhandled:** A ‘comedy’ starring Richard Dix (*The Ten Commandments*) that isn’t very funny. Also, I am not sure I get the appeal of Richard Dix, he doesn’t come off as very funny, nor is he charming enough to play the leading man. The plot itself doesn’t provide the comedy needed: a rich NYCer goes to his uncle’s ranch in Texas to ‘man up’ and experience ‘the west’ to show his crush

he is worth marrying. Turns out the west isn't so wild any more. Yet there are not enough laughs from this premise (trying to make the ranch rough-and-tumble when the girl visits, does not provide laughs). However they still fall in love, and the realization that doing the 'work' to create the ruse is enough to know he loves her works, enough. [Richard Dix]

53. **Dick Turpin:** Tom Mix (*Sky High*) stars in this costume adventure, which despite not being a Western, still has lots of hall marks of the genre; including him riding around on a horse and getting into fights. He plays the titular anti-hero, though the film does not exactly make the character very complex. Kathleen Myers (*Go West*) is decent. A proper restoration probably improves the ranking slightly as then the costumes and sets would be easier to see and improve the overall quality. [Tom Mix]
52. **Sally, Irene and Mary:** A melodrama that eventually develops some stakes, but one where everything happens far too quickly and rashly. The three titular ladies star in a show, and bounce around between men. The men perusing naturally change their interests from one woman to another. The three female leads are rather good despite being 'unknowns' at the time: Constance Bennett, Sally O'Neil, and Joan Crawford. But again, are let down by a plot that zips around without taking the time to motivate the actions of their characters. [Joan Crawford]
51. **Wolf Blood:** An early werewolf film, but more of a precursor to the genre as this would not be a werewolf film by modern standards. As the lead is 'given' wolf's blood to save his life after a fight and then begin to think he is part-wolf. However all that entails is wanting to go out and join the wolves at night. The double exposure of the wolves 'calling' him makes for a good scene. Yet beyond that, the film is fairly standard as neither George Chesebro or Marguerite Clayton bring much to the film. [On YouTube]
50. **Sally of the Sawdust:** D.W. Griffith (*The Love Flower*, *Dream Street*, *One Exciting Night*, *Isn't Life Wonderful*) continues his string of low-ranking films. This two-hour slog, would be in the bottom tier if it wasn't for the talents of W.C. Fields in his feature film debut. Fields comedy chops inject a few laughs (any of his con-man acts, and anything he gets to with his hat and cane), despite Griffith not have a single clue how to direct a comedy. Carol Dempster (also in those same four films) is okay, her dancing sequences are decent, and the costumes for them are rather good. Instead of being a brisk romantic comedy, Griffith once again prefers to direct a long melodrama, complete with a chase sequence leading to a will-he-make-it-in-time faux suspense (at least his earlier films filled these ending sequences with excitement, but he hasn't found that sauce since *Way Down East*). Griffith continues to direct awful films that comprise the bottom to second-to-last tier. [D.W. Griffith]
49. **Kentucky Pride:** An early family-friendly John Ford film about race horses. The film does take the perspective of the horse, which is a nice twist, but it does get a bit grating as the film goes on (especially the horse's 'voice' comes across as being aimed towards children understanding). There are a few racist moments such as the butler (who is at least credited on screen) and that one of the horses we are suppose to cheer for is named Confederacy. However, the film isn't as straight-forward as one would expect, which means it can rank at the top of this tier. [John Ford]

### Tier 6: Generic Popular Films of the Day

48. **Too Many Kisses:** Even though the film is only sixty minutes long, it is entirely predictable. The film does feature a young William Powell (*Romola*), who does add some spiciness as the villain. Richard Dix (*Womanhandled*) is the star, but doesn't do much besides win the girl. Perhaps the film is most known for being the first film for Harpo Marx and his only 'line' (it is a silent, so he still doesn't 'speak'). But Harpo has only two scenes and even in those he is a minor character. The film is never awful, but far too standard to ever excel in any way. [Harpo Marx]

47. **The Midnight Girl:** Lila Lee (*Blood and Sand*) plays the titular Midnight Girl, a Russian immigrant (fleeing the evil Soviets!) who wants to make it in the America Opera scene. Bela Lugosi stars as the wealthy (and horny) opera patron. There isn't much drama besides who wants to sleep with who. But by the end of the film, everything is worked out (despite someone accidentally getting shot?) and people marry who they really love and live happily ever after. [Grapevine Video Kickerstarter]
46. **The Chronicles of the Grey House (Zur Chronik von Grieshuus):** The film is a standard melodrama of a nobleman falling in love and marrying a peasant woman. All of the 'drama' follows from that. Therefore the squabbles over inheritance and such fall flat. The filming locations are decent along with costumes. But nothing can overcome a generic plot, when the set-up of the downfall (the plot is shown as a flashback after someone stumbles upon the ruins of the house) could have been far better. [Grapevine Video]
45. **Wild Horse Mesa:** A clunky plot, with a few too many characters. There are multiple villains (who eventually 'team up' over their shared love of mauling horses, but disagree when it comes to raping women). A major plot point is that the lead hero is 'friendly' with Native American squaws (don't worry, it is later revealed that he was 'just friends' with them, so he can marry the white girl). A subplot about the white horse leader of the wild horses is never developed but comes back at the end for little reason. The on-location filming is decent and possibly the only saving grace. [Grapevine Video]
44. **Daughters Who Pay:** A great example of a zany silent film plot: a sister needs to get her brother out of a pinch (stealing 10k from his job), so she goes to the boss – the father of 'her boyfriend' – except her boyfriend knows her only as an exotic Russian dancer. However she is only working as a cabaret girl to spy on the Reds! Gotta love some of these plots. The final reel suffers from a lot of decomposition which is shame. Bela Lugosi has a supporting role as the head of the Soviet 'underground' (the film doesn't really get into their evil doings). Marguerite De La Motte (*The Three Musketeers*) is rather good in the good role, and honestly fooled me for a bit with her Clark Kent glasses. It is an enjoyable little film, even if the plot is outlandish. [Bela Lugosi]
43. **Headlines:** The film is held together by the performances of its two female leads: Alice Joyce (who was thirty-five at the time, and playing the mother) and Virginia Lee Corbin (who was thirteen or fourteen at the time, playing the seventeen year old daughter). Even with different 'standards' back then on marrying age, it doesn't feel great to watch. As the daughter is extremely flirtatious, and even has a late-nite rendezvous with a wealthy, married, and much older man (which if found out would create the titular headlines). Everything does get worked out, and the bright spot is Alice Joyce's character development as a concerned mother. [Grapevine Video]
42. **The Calgary Stampede:** The main bright spot of the film is Hoot Gibson's rodeo work (who was one of the bigger, but not the biggest, popular western star). The other benefit is the wildlife shots, especially buffalo on the plains. However, outside that the plot is rather standard and weak plot points to generate melodrama: Hoot's character is accused of murder because the 'half-breed' who saw her boyfriend doing the shooting lies! Hoot saves the day at the rodeo because the his kindly ranch-owning boss is *twice* called a piker and ups the bet each time to eventually *to include his entire ranch!* that his ranch hands will beat those of an adversary. It is that kind of film. [Hoot Gibson]
41. **Zander the Great:** The first of two Marion Davies (*When Knighthood was in Flower*) films on the list. Again the plot is a bit basic with some laughs. Davies is a decent comedian, but not good enough to carry the film. The opening orphanage scenes are not as funny as the film thinks they are. The film does succeed in having a positive portrayal of a Mexican character (who essentially saves the day). Harrison Ford is decent and gets to be evil for a few minutes, before deciding he loves Marion Davies' character. Yet, at the end of the day the film is generic entertainment. [Marion Davies]

40. **Lady of the Night:** There are two reasons to watch this film: Norma Shearer (*He Who Gets Slapped*) and the titular lady of the night (though her profession is weakly implied) and Norma Shearer as the virginal daughter of a wealthy banker. She is great in both roles and carries the film (a young Joan Crawford fills in as her double in the scene where both characters are on-screen at the same time). As besides her the film is rather basic with a distinct stick-to-your-class feel and characters who are not developed beyond their social status. [Norma Shearer]
39. **Cobra:** The bright spot of the film is Rudolph Valentino (*Monsieur Beaucaire*), who brings the needed charm and compassion to the leading role. Except that is about where the positives stop. The film, at a little over an hour, is still rushed with a haphazard plot. There is a lengthy opening sequence with Valentino's character in Italy, but far too much of the sequence is not needed and adds little to character development (outside of meeting his new friend and deciding to come to America). Once in America, the plot again progresses far too quickly with an engagement, and affairs, and death. Which is a shame, because Valentino's character is a good one, and he plays the part well. The rest of the film lets him down. [Rudolph Valentino]
38. **His Master's Voice:** A non-Rin-Tin-Tin dog picture, this one starring Thunder. The first fifteen-ish are a bit hokey and one begins to wonder if they are watching a dud instead of a dog. The premise is too hokey; Thunder tells his adorable puppy about how he fixed things for their master. The film then starts to proceed as a generic shy-guy loves a girl, but risks losing her to the unscrupulous rival. Once the war starts, then the film gets going and characters are developed a bit. Though the message that war toughens you up (if you have a good dog to help you through it) isn't exactly the best. The war scenes are decent, but nothing special. [Kino]
37. **The Circle:** Directed by Frank Borzage (*Back Pay*) the film is a nice little comedy that at times acts as a comedy-of-remarriage; the mother leaves a marriage, and then her daughter-in-law must decide if she also wants to leave her marriage. The film does have a few iffy parts about woman's roles. Eleanor Boardman (*Souls for Sale*) is solid in the leading role (and Joan Crawford makes a brief appearance as the young mother when initially leaving the marriage). There are a few good laughs, although some of them get repeated too much (mainly how 'old' the eloping couple have gotten compared to the left-behind husband). There are still enough laughs to make the film tolerable. [Frank Borzage]
36. **A Kiss for Cinderella:** The available print is in rough shape. A proper restoration might move the film up a tier as the sets and costumes would look a lot better. Betty Bronson (*Peter Pan*) is good as Cinderella. Although the plot is a tad forced as it starts out about WWI England, and turns into a Cinderella fantasy. The turning of the pumpkin into the carriage is a nice special effect, and the rotating camera shot at the ball. The film could be a tad shorter, as a few points are hammered home. [Betty Bronson]
35. **The Rag Man:** Jackie Coogan essentially reprises his role from *The Kid* in this film about an Irish orphan who befriends a Jewish junk collector. The film works best with their characters growing to love each other, and ignoring the stereotypes of the day (as neither Jews nor the Irish were held in great respect). Coogan's charm when purchasing junk is great, but again, it is nearly a repeat of *The Kid*. The film very well could be a little bit better than this, but too often it feels like you'd rather be watching a far superior 'version' from 1921.
34. **Lorraine of the Lions:** A 'reverse' Tarzan, about the Queen of the Jungle, who is found and brought back to society. Some of the animal shots are nice (ignoring that the gorilla is a man in a costume). The dresses are nicely done. The 'gorilla' does an early *King Kong* sequence, but it never has the necessary drama or action to make it truly captivating. Norman Kerry and Patsy Ruth Miller are once again good together (*The Hunchback of Notre Dame*). The film is a decent hour of

entertainment with solid actors and production values, even if the drama brings nothing to the table. [Undercrank Productions Restoration]

33. **Are Parents People?:** A comedy of remarriage that focuses a bit more on how it affects their daughter. Betty Bronson (*Peter Pan*) plays the daughter decently, but a few too many times is over does trying to portray girlish charm. Adolphe Menjou (*The Sheik*) and Florence Vidor are both solid as the parents. Yet the plot is a bit too standard to rank any higher, and the jokes aren't not as plentiful as they should be. [Betty Bronson]
32. **The Clash of the Wolves:** Rin-Tin-Tin (*Where the North Begins*) carries a basic film. His stunt work is not as good as previous films. In fact, most of his action is running thru Joshua Tree National Park and climbing said Joshua Trees. Heinie Conklin (*Keystone Cops*) hams it up too much as the comedic relief character and practically ruins the movie every time he is on screen. The film focuses a bit too much on the love-interests instead of letting Rinty cook, though both actors are capable that it isn't a let down. [Rin-Tin-Tin]
31. **Little Annie Rooney:** Mary Pickford (*Little Lord Fauntleroy*) is still playing the little girl, despite now being thirty-three. Pickford's acting is the best part of the film, even if she over does it at times. The sets are nice, and the other child actors perform well enough. The film does have generally positive things to say about the immigrant experience and American melting pot (even if a few immigrants end up having to be the bad guys in the plot), but compared to how other films portrayed Jews and the Chinese, this is a few steps above the others. [Mary Pickford]

#### Tier 5: Well-Made (and Bigger Budget) Popular Movies

30. **The Monster:** A horror-comedy directed by Roland West that follows in the vein of previous spooky-house films. The comedy is on full display, and the early-horror is kept to a minimum (often times cross across as an early Scooby-Doo film). Although Lon Chaney is in the film, and given top billing, he is a supporting character and gets the fourth-most screen time. He is decent in his role, but was not able to crank his creepy up to eleven. Even with a toned-down performance Chaney steals the show, but the other actors are not given much to work with (no one is) and therefore they can't muster a solid performance. Enjoy the few laughs, and some good spooky shots of shadows and hands coming out of secret passages. [Lon Chaney]
29. **Tumbleweeds:** The final film for William S. Hart (*The Toll Gate*), after all he was sixty. In the context of a great actor's final film it works a bit more as his character forgoes (and laments the end of) the open range to eventually settle down and marry (spoiler! oops). That is a nice send-off for an iconic western star. However, in doing so the film doesn't have the same moral complexities shown in his more famous films (he does escape jail to save the day, but besides that not much law breaking for him). The villains are basic land thieves, with the only complication being that their sister is the love interest. For all the basic plot developments, the editing and cinematography for the start of the land rush is excellent; the cuts from close-ups of watches, the open plains, the eager homesteaders, and the cannon are great. I'm a tad sad there wont be another William S. Hart film on these lists going forward. [William S. Hart]
28. **Lights of Old Broadway:** A comedy with Marion Davies (*When Knighthood Was in Flower*) with a twins-separated-at-birth premise about social class. Much of the film is rather basic, but there are a few laughs and the plot is a bit outlandish (who doesn't see someone who looks identical to their adopted sister and instantly decided to try and lock that down?). The stuff about the Irish, was certainly a choice (but the film does allow the Irish to become successful, if a bit by chance). The highlights of the film are color sequences and the hand stenciling of the US flag, in a patriotic and pro-technology sequence. Otherwise the film is a bit basic entertainment. [Marion Davies]

27. **The Freshman:** I have never exactly been a Harold Lloyd (*Safety Last!* and *Girl Shy*) hater, but his films would often rank below Keaton and Chaplin. *The Freshman* is frequently cited as his second-best film, and yet I found it to be one of his more grating. His go-getter shtick drives the plot, but is annoying. The character is difficult to illicit much sympathy. Too many of the gags, are nonsensical and continue for too long (the suit falling apart because the alcoholic tailor couldn't get a drink and didn't finish the suit isn't that funny and lasts a long time; as Lloyd supporters will claim, it captures the essence of the time!). The famous ending football sequence is not funny. Perhaps it is only funny to people without an understanding of football, as the sequence is not grounded in any sense of reality; teams are punting on what appears to be first down, there are random changes of possession. (the jock strap as a face protector was great though.) I'm left to believe that the reason this film ranks highly is that all of the film-loving, un-athletic losers found a hero in the film. [Harold Lloyd]
26. **The Unholy Three:** The first of two Tod Browning (*White Tiger*) directed films on the list. The film has some Browning hallmarks: mainly great shadows and circus/carnivals/scam-artists. The titular unholy three are often initial shown by only their shadows in shots that look great and moody. Lon Chaney is great as the mastermind of the three, and once again shows of his make-up skills by pretending to be an old lady as part of the scam. He once again plays a morally complex character rather well (a high definition restoration would aid the film and make it easier to appreciate his acting). The surprise star of the film is Harry Earles (who would reunite with Browning in *Freaks* and go on to be one of the Munchkins in *The Wizard of Oz*) who pretends to be a baby as part of the scam. He is great in the role as he effortlessly switches from sweet baby to mischievous devil. [Tod Browning and Lon Chaney]
25. **Ben-Hur: A Tale of the Christ:** I had watched the 1959 version first. And if anything, the review is still the same: the naval battle and chariot race are epic pieces of grand filmmaking. Everything shoe-horning in Jesus makes the plot bog down and dull (and the silent version didn't have Charlton Heston). In the silent version, the naval scene is not as impactful, mainly because in the silent era there were multiple swashbuckler films with sailing ship and sword fights. The chariot race still remains great with solid editing, and wonderful camera placements (the shots of the horses going over the camera are great). The two-strip color sequences are a nice addition, but even those exist because Jesus is in the scene. The spectacle and production is solid, but the drama is not. [An OG Bun-Hur]
24. **The Red Kimona:** The film is based on a real-life subject (there was a controversy about using the person's real name and the case is cited in right-to-be-forgotten literature) of a girl forced into prostitution. The drama is there, but often the film makes sure the audience gets the message (the hand coloring of the kimona and transition from the wedding dress in the mirror to the kimona are both great' the scarlet letter appearing when she eventually is free and applying for jobs—not so much). Priscilla Bonner flip-flops between nailing the part and overdoing it. Often within the same scene. [In a Boxset on Women Directors]
23. **Don Q, Son of Zorro:** This film should probably be a tier lower. Except Douglas Fairbanks (*The Mark of Zorro*, *The Three Musketeers*, *Robin Hood*, *The Thief of Baghdad*) still has it. The film is inferior to his previous action films, and the shine is beginning to fade. The action is not as swift as the others. The sets are not as extravagant. The special effects – sans briefly having Zorro and his son (both played by Fairbanks) on screen at the same time – are not as innovative. Perhaps as it was directed by Donald Crisp (*The Navigator*), who is a solid director, but usually did more comedy. Yet, for all of that, Fairbanks is still damn charming. Watching him outsmart the various villains and get the girl is still a fun time. Add in a young Mary Astor (*Beau Brummel*), the film is worthwhile. [Sequel]

22. **The Mystic:** Realistically, this film should rank a tier higher, as the film is directed by Tod Browning (*Outside the Law*). As the only reason for being here is the new score by Dean Hurley (*Inland Empire*). One wonders if Hurley has ever watched a silent film with the score. The issue isn't that the score is 'modern' (not a simple organ), but rather it features a lot of sound synchronization: knocks on doors, phones ringing, knives being thrown, clapping, etc. Silent films did not have sound! Sound synchronization occurred 1927–1930ish, before full sound took over completely. The 'synchronization' takes the viewer out of the film and practically ruins the experience. Criterion should know better. Rant over. Onto the film. The gowns by Erté are amazing. The plot itself is solid, with nice character development, especially that of the 'mastermind' character who falls in love. The behind-the-scenes look at the mystic con is a nice touch, with multiple details of how the scam actually works. [Tod Browning]
21. **Maciste in Hell (Maciste all'inferno):** I have not seen any of the other *Maciste* films, so I might have missed a few references or pieces of character development. Bartolomeo Pagano fits the bill as the titular hero, as sometimes looking the part is all that matters. The scenes on Earth are a bit basic, however once the film moves to Hell, things get going. The sets on Hell are nice, same with the make-up and costumes. Some of the effects take a bit from *Häxan*, which is fine, though they are often inferior. The costumes for the She-Devils are a sight. [Early Horror]
20. **Whirlpool of Fate (La Fille de l'eau):** The directorial debut of Jean Renoir (*being the son of Pierre-Auguste Renoir*). Renoir's direction does its best to save the movie. For instance there is a great shot of a character walking along the houseboat as it sails down the canal so the camera does not move, and the character is essentially stationary in the frame, as the boat moves on down. A dream/hallucination sequence is also well done (especially the flowing gown). However, the plot is a standard melodrama. And once the uncle returns the film causes a few face palms (tell the kindly rich guy your uncle is stealing the money from you). Renoir's first isn't a classic, but it shows a few flashes of what is to come. [Jean Renoir]

#### Tier 4: A Singular Aspect is Perfect

19. **A Woman of the World:** Pola Negri (*The Spanish Dancer*) can carry a romantic-comedy. She is sultry, which we knew from her previous films, but her looks and glances help sell jokes. She is a main reason the film ranks in this tier as she is excellent in the film. A lesser actress and this risks becoming a routine romance. Director Malcolm St. Clair (*Are Parents People?*) also helps elevate the film by well-timed close ups. For example, during a 'break-up' the director focuses on the hands leaving the room and the eventual closing of the door. Most of the jokes are good, and because of the direction and actioning, even ones that might have been considered hokey land. [Pola Negri]
18. **Go West:** One of Buster Keaton's weaker offerings. The gags are a bit more sparse than usual. Yet it is as touching as a film can be about a man's love for his cow. If anything the film is more tender than comedic. Once the bulls get loose, literally, the comedy greatly improves (and the spectacle of controlling a hundred cows on a film set). The stunts are also a bit limited compared to his great films. With the only big ones, naturally, involving a train. Some of the edits and chases are nicely done. A weaker Keaton is still better than what most people can create. [Buster Keaton]
17. **Paths to Paradise:** The film is incomplete; the final reel is missing. The events of the final reel are provided with title cards, although it does not exactly hamper the enjoyment of the overall film. There are some nice shots with shadows (including two people cast large upon a building). Raymond Griffith is rather charming and funny in the lead as a smooth-operating con-man. Betty Compson is rather good as the love-interest and a competing con-lady. There are a few solid comedy bits; Griffith's character playing detective for the wealthy people is probably the best. [Undercrank Productions Restoration]



16. **The Lost World:** The practical effects are amazing. The dinosaurs all look great (at least five different kinds are shown). The film does an excellent job of incorporating the dinosaurs in the same frame as the humans as well (multiple times). There is also even dinosaur blood when the creatures fight. Subtle items such as having the dinos breathe, eat trees, wag their tails, and have water running or mud flowing really add to the wonder. The effects are not cheap, but show a commitment to detail which elevates the film another tier. These are not merely plastic dinos added to a thrill, but well-thought out effects of a mastermind in Willis H. O'Brien. Wallace Beery is great as the eccentric professor. Bessie Love and Lloyd Hughes are decent as the love-interest leads. The script is well-written as most of the plot developments and solutions are organic (such as the use of the monkey's character and purpose). It does bog down a little bit towards the end, resulting in it not ranking one tier higher. [Famous Special Effects]
15. **The Phantom of the Opera:** I watched the 1925 version (the most 'famous' version of the film is actually a 1929 re-release which was massively re-edited). Except the BFI restoration focused on restoring only the 1929 version. Therefore the original version does look rough at times, nor does it feature tinting, or—and most important lacks the technicolor sequences. (Seriously, why didn't BFI compare elements and 'reuse' the better ones from the 1929 version when they appear in the original?) As these technical achievements do improve the film. The sets are rather good; the catacombs and opera house. Lon Chaney (*The Penalty*) is great, and his make-up work is once again phenomenal, and essentially carries the film. Norman Kerry (*Lorraine of the Lions*) continues to be a serviceable and charming leading man. The film is an excellent production, but is still in need of a proper restoration for the original 1925 version. [Lon Chaney]
14. **Seven Chances:** A quick and simply hour-long film from Buster Keaton (*Sherlock Jr*). It is not one of his best, though his bests are contenders for best of all time. The color opening is nice, and sets the stage for the film. Asking the women in the club to be married was a nice gag—especially asking the hat-check lady. The bride chase is decent, but reminiscent of Keaton's previous chases involving cops. The rolling rocks is funny, but not funny enough to completely save the film. Keaton still remains one of the best, but this year was a down year for him. [Buster Keaton]
13. **Body and Soul:** Written and directed by Oscar Micheaux (*Within Our Gates*) the film continues his realistic African-American dramas. Now, before the film can be analyzed, once again how bad the score is needs to be mentioned. 'DJ Spooky's' score is god awful, an awkward mix of jazz and modern drum beats, most of which rarely matches the action on screen (it baffles me that these awful scores keep getting approved for disks). Paul Robeson is great as the 'preacher' as he is able to walk the line of being evil, but getting by due to sheer charisma (and also being a preacher gives his character a line of defense). Whereas Mercedes Gilbert was not as good. The direction of the rape scene is rather good, a bare bones way of implying it without showing (though one does wonder what the original nine-reel cut showed compared to the striped down and surviving five-reeler). [Oscar Micheaux]
12. **The Eagle:** Finally a film to showcase Rudolph Valentino's (*Cobra*) talents. Valentino still brings his charm and delicate mannerism, but is no longer let down by a bad script and cheap direction. In this film the camera moves (a shot going down the long dinning table is the most impressive), and the editing adds a bit to the action sequences. It still is a love story (one must use his talents wisely), yet here there is an early meet-cute that helps develop the plot in multiple ways. The film is well-made fun with a talented cast. [Rudolph Valentino]
11. **The Late Mathais Pascal (Feu Mathias Pascal):** Written and directed by Marcel L'Herbier (*L'Inhumaine*). The film is a constant tug-of-war between L'Herbiers excellent direction and set, plus Ivan Mosjoukine (*Kean*) against the meandering plot that takes too long. Mosjoukine by himself is responsible for the film's ranking, and could easily justify moving into the next tier. His comedic

chops are that good (asking out his first wife, and the hand-holding during the seance are two of his best moments). The sets are rather good, especially the ‘crowded’ library and his Rome apartment (I’ll ignore the poor geographical handling of some of the Roman scenes). Perhaps the best scene is the reflecting back while staring at the train tracks. It is a beautifully double-exposed, hypnotic, and conveys the feeling of staring out a train window. Yet for all the three hours, there are plenty of jokes, but not much drama. And comedies are a filmy genre that needed be long. The film also never gets surreal enough in the second half (there are some dream-like sequences, but never enough). If the film leaned into being surreal (actors playing multiple roles, instead of look-a-likes—the first half features a Pomino while the second features a similar-looking Papiano, and leaning into the idea that he has indeed died). The film is rather good, but was a few choices away from being excellent. [Marcel L’Herbier]

10. **Stage Struck:** Gloria Swanson (*Zaza* and *Manhandled*) carries the film. She is the always the proper amount of charming, shy, and most importantly funny. Her facial reactions are great and lift up jokes which weren’t the funniest to greatness. The opening two-strip technicolor sequence is funny with amazing production values. The gowns used are gorgeous. Director Allan Dwan (*Robin Hood*) handles the production nicely; although there are not many flourishes, the details are great (such as the boxing fight and the kitchen window) where a lesser director would not have done the scene justice. [Gloria Swanson]
9. **Variety (Variété):** The film ranks here because of Karl Freund’s (*The Last Laugh*) cinematography. The camera moves around and dazzles as if itself was part of the trapeze act. The superimposing of the vaudeville acts in the patron’s binoculars is great as well. The shots of the circus themselves are a great special effect as well. The film looks great. Sadly, that is about where the accolades end. Emil Jannings (*The Last Laugh*) is not given a character to do much with so his talent isn’t fully realized. Likewise the plot has a few holes, with the most egregious one also setting up the second half of the film. Had a bit more thought been put into the plot and character development, the film would easily be in the next year as the camera work is often amazing. [Karl Freund]

### Tier 3: Must Watch Territory

8. **Strike:** A film I had seen multiple times before the list, which dampens some of the impact. The film is Soviet propaganda and that hurts the character development and plot; as the villains are often cartoon villains and the businessmen are lampoons of businessmen. The film also avoids much character development, instead focusing on the themes it wants to convey; resulting in the middle of the film bogging down. The visuals inside the factory are great and the machinery spinning is nice (even if those images were done better in *La Roue*). Some of the editing is top notch and inventive. There are a few great match cuts. The editing of the suicide is textbook. The frequent foreshadowing (the map running ‘red’ with spilled ink being the best) is nice. The ending sequence is a tour de force, albeit a grotesque one. It was shocking then, and still shocking now. Sergei Eisenstein’s first feature is a monumental one. [Sergei Eisenstein]
7. **The Merry Widow:** Directed by Erich von Stroheim (*Greed*), the film contains most of his hallmarks: elaborate sets and extras, solid camera work and editing, and being extremely horny. One almost wonders how many of the scenes got past the censors. John Gilbert (*He Who Gets Slapped*) is great as the ‘good’ cousin, although despite not being completely evil and creepy, is still a horny sleaze for most of the film, and Gilbert’s talent alone is able to make the character charming despite the obvious flaws, which is needed as he is to be the love interest. Whereas Roy D’Arcy plays the ‘evil’ cousin perfectly, the sleaze, creepiness, and horny are all extravagant. The gowns are are great (the dress Mae Murray wears at her reception is amazing, and only outdone by the effect of showing how D’Arcy’s character only sees her for her jewels/money). There are a few too many plot contrivances

to allow the film to rank higher, especially at the end as things are quickly tidied up. Yet, Stroheim continues to make great films. [Erich von Stroheim]

6. **Lady Windermere's Fan:** Directed by Ernst Lubitsch (*The Marriage Circle*), and he is able to elevate the Oscar Wilde source material. The source material develops characters and does so in a way that avoids cliché while also keeping a few secrets to reveal later on. Lubitsch's direction only highlights the development and confusion. His blocking, often keeping one character off screen (or behind something) aids in the gossiping and who's-seeing-who. One particularly excellent shot involves a character catching up with another walking down the street, and the camera slowly blocks off the picture behind the trailing character. Lubitsch continues to make these adult romantic dramedies and they are far superior to the predictable romances of the era. May McAvoy (*The Mad Whirl*) and Irene Rich (*Beau Brummel*) are great as the female leads and convey the needed emotion with subtlety. Also the costumes are rather nice. This film is a great production through and through. [Ernst Lubitsch]
5. **Master of the House (Du skal ære din hustru):** Written and directed by Carl Theodor Dreyer (*Michael* and *Leaves from Satan's Book*) continues his excellent dramas. The film could almost be considered an early comedy-of-remarriage, as there are funny bits, but the film is very much a drama. The only knock is the film is heavy-handed, but when one realizes no other films were portraying separation this realistically (an abusive husband; not simply wanting to cheat or feeling neglected; that the man is the sole problem) the film is able to shine. Few, if any films, are this aggressively pro-women and their rights. Dreyer does not employ as many cinematic flourishes as previous films (mainly a lot of iris shots). The three leads: Mathilde Nielsen (*The Parson's Widow*), Astrid Holm (*The Phantom Carriage*), and Johannes Meyer are all great. Dreyer is a legendary director for a reason. [Carl Theodor Dreyer]
4. **Faces of Children (Visages d'enfants):** Co-written and directed by Jacques Feyder (*Crainque-bille*). He remains an underrated, and overlooked, French director. The film is shot in the Swiss Alps and the cinematography makes great use of the setting. There are gorgeous snowscapes, lush hills, raging rivers, and distant shots of the small town. The film looks great and makes excellent use of its on-location filming. What allows the film to excel is the realistic, and flawed, characters that drive the action. A basic plot of a father getting remarried after the death of his wife, and children from both sides learning to deal with their new living conditions. The children are realistic children with their issues of new siblings and parents. Similarly the flawed adults, often make matters worse with actions. The film is a well-crafted drama with excellent characters. [Jacques Feyder]

## Tier 2: Near Masterpieces

3. **The Big Parade:** Directed by King Vidor (*Wild Oranges*), this is one of the finest war films ever made, and set the standard for most every war film that follows. The first hour is more comedic than drama, and if anything there is a bit too much comedy during the lengthy farmhouse sequence. The romance between John Gilbert's (*The Merry Widow*) character and the farm maiden is great, charming, and realistic (his character has a fiancée back at home, but love is love—the film's realism can not be overstated). His two friends, who engage in various hijinks (remember, too much comedy) are developed enough, and a fair bit of their hijinks come back as plot points (spitting and being 'it' are the best callbacks). These still remain real people, and not stand-ins for social commentary or forced patriotism, yet if these were trimmed down a bit the film would rank higher (though I assume the comedy was needed for audiences to survive what comes next). After about an hour and a half, the war scenes kick in, and the film truly shines. The march thru the woods is harrowing with excellent editing, tracking shots, and editing. The war scenes continue in No-Man's-Land, with many sequences creating the standard for all other war movies to emulate. The editing of cannons,

tanks, planes, machine guns, gas, etc show the deadly weapons of war and most shots are done with great special effects as well. The ending risks some spoilers, but for 1925, it still strikes the a good balance of realism and sentimentality. [King Vidor]

2. **The Gold Rush:** One of Chaplin's (*The Kid*) best films, and follows the classic tramp formula of comedy, pathos, and a touch of melodrama. Chaplin is excellent at evoking pity for the tramp in ways that never come across as forced; the New Year's Eve 'dinner' is an absolute masterclass in this regard. Many of the gags are all-timers; the dancing bread, the bear, eating a shoes, shoveling snow, everything to do with the cabin on the edge of the mountain. The tilting cabin is one best sequences ever; from both a comedy and technical perspective (fans of *Interstellar* should give it a watch). For as much as I prefer Keaton's brand of comedy to Chaplin's which is pulling at your heartstrings, even I need to admit when the pulling works. [Charlie Chaplin]

### Tier 1: Sergei Eisenstein's Masterpiece

1. **Battleship Potemkin:** Directed (and edited) by Sergei Eisenstein (*Strike*), he continues everything great with his debut film, but provides more character motivation and tones down the in-your-face nature. Here the mutiny starts because of mistreatment from the tsar's officers. The mutiny is not explicitly tied to the communist uprising, only poor conditions on the ship. As later on in the film, the ship eventually raises (a gorgeously hand-stenciled) red flag to show their solidarity. Similarly, the anti-religious propaganda is deftly incorporated; the smashing of a plate which read 'Give us this day our daily bread' makes sense as the shipmen are starving (their meat is infested with maggots; the shots of the maggots are great) while the officers eat plenty (the smashing of the plate itself is a great editorial achievement). The lull of the third section is needed as it sets up the ships role in the larger revolution; that after meeting with the citizens of Odessa they come to their aid. Now, what is there to say about The Odessa Staircase sequence? It is perhaps the greatest twelve minutes in the history of film. Minor characters are highlighted waving to the ship before the cossacks attack. These same characters are then tracked during the massacre. The suspense of the stroller tumbling down. The editing and cinematography is amazing; I haven't mentioned the cuts from the shelling to the awakening of the lion! Without the Odessa Steps, the film is still probably in next tier, as the first two sequences are well-shot and edited. Adding in one of the greatest sequences in film history, easily then puts the film in rarefied air of the all-time masterpieces.